Home Fire Escape Plan

From the free guide at https://jaechung-glitch.github.io/bugout/guides/what-to-do-in-a-house-fire/, which lists its sources (Oregon State Fire Marshal and Milpitas Fire Department guidance). Updated November 12, 2026.

General safety information, not medical advice or a substitute for training. In an emergency, call 911.

How to escape a house fire

1. **Get out first.** Fire spreads fast, and you may have as little as two minutes. Leave everything behind.
2. **Test doors.** Feel the door with the back of your hand. If it's hot or smoke is coming under it, use another way out. If it's cool, open it slowly.
3. **Stay low.** Crawl under smoke, where the air is cleaner and cooler. Cover your nose and mouth with a cloth if you can.
4. **Close doors behind you** to slow the fire and smoke.
5. **Use stairs, never elevators,** in an apartment building.
6. **Go to your meeting place** outside and call 911.
7. **Stay out.** Tell firefighters if anyone is still inside; don't go back in yourself.

If your clothes catch fire: stop, drop and roll. Stop where you are, drop to the ground, cover your face with your hands, and roll until the flames are out. Running feeds the fire.

If you're trapped

- [ ] Close the door between you and the fire
- [ ] Seal gaps around doors and vents with towels, clothes or duct tape
- [ ] Call 911 and say exactly where you are
- [ ] Stay near a window and close to the floor
- [ ] Signal firefighters with a light-colored cloth or a flashlight at the window

How to make a home fire escape plan

- [ ] Draw a map of your home with two ways out of every room, usually a door and a window
- [ ] Make sure windows open easily and that screens and security bars can be removed from inside
- [ ] Pick an outside meeting place a safe distance away, such as a tree, light pole or mailbox
- [ ] Put smoke alarms on every level, outside sleeping areas and in every bedroom
- [ ] Make sure everyone knows the sound of the smoke alarm
- [ ] Sleep with bedroom doors closed to slow smoke and fire
- [ ] Assign someone to help babies, older adults and anyone with a disability
- [ ] Practice the plan at least twice a year, including at night